They were not like Nehru or EMS Namboothiripad who were ashamed of being called a Hindu.'[25]

This conflation of Hindutva with Hinduism, of course, is a claim that remains deeply contested, and has been challenged by many. In early 2020, I debated ideas of Hinduism with the Congress politician and former diplomat Shashi Tharoor as we discussed his book, *Why I Am a Hindu.* Tharoor argued strongly that his Hinduism harked back to the multi-formed polytheistic traditions of Hinduism, which were the very opposite of the uniform notion of Hinduism that the RSS upholds.[26]

In fact, when Tharoor's book on Hinduism was first published in 2018, *Organiser* published an angry response titled 'Exasperating Farrago'. Its reviewer argued that Tharoor's thesis was symptomatic of a 'race for proving Hindu credentials among secular politicians'. The magazine rejected his argument as an attempt to 'impose a Western framework of Hinduism on Hindus' and a 'dangerous ploy to snatch away Hindutva from the common Bharatiyas'. It attacked him for 'forgetting the fact that what he calls "Hinduism" includes many religions and what he differentiates as "Hindutva" are the common characteristics of these religions'. The reviewer was further incensed by Tharoor's defence of individual Hinduisms and his usage of the expression 'My Hinduism' because '"My Hinduism" is the most un-Hindu expression one can have staying and living within the fold of Hindutva'. *Organiser* went on to argue that 'Hindutva has no "ism", like the way one would have Islamism, Christianism or Judaism', and that it could never be 'mine or your Hinduism or Hindutva'. It asked, 'Do you say "my Sikhism" or "Islamism"?' before concluding that Tharoor was 'trivialising the entire narrative on a matter which has thousands of years of penance and thought behind it'. For the RSS, Tharoor's construction of 'Hindutva versus Hinduism, secularism versus nationalism' was an example of 'RSS bashing'.[27]

Tharoor, on the other hand, contended that the 'Islamicised Hinduism' of the Sangh Parivar and the 'sectarian notion of Hindutva', as he put it, was a 'travesty of what Hinduism really is'. The Sangh's idea of Hinduism, he argued, 'does not speak' for Hindus like him.[28] For secular liberals, the basic divide has always been that Hindutva is political while Hinduism is not; Hinduism is